of ancient India and the decadence of the West. He began by taking us through every twist and turn in the story told in the *Ramayana* of how the Bhagirathi River – which we were then following to its source – got its name. So we heard all about King Sagar and how his sixty thousand sons in their search for the sacrificial horse required for the *Ashwamedha yagna*, the ancient Vedic horse sacrifice, had disturbed the sage Kapila as he sat in meditation, causing the sage to open his eyes and blast the sons to ashes. For their unquiet souls to ascend to Swarga (heaven) their ashes had to be immersed in the waters of the sacred Ganga River, which then flowed only in Swarga and not on earth. We learned how the good King Bhagirath, in order to make this possible, had retired to the mountains to perform the arduous meditation known as *tapasya*, which he did for a thousand years until Lord Brahma granted his wish to bring the Ganga to earth. We learned how Lord Shiva had caught the river's falling waters in his matted locks – the Himalayas – and so brought the mighty Ganga to earth, making it possible for Bhagirath to immerse his ancestor's ashes in its sacred waters.

It is a captivating myth, inspiring one of the most audacious sculptures ever created, carved thirteen centuries ago across the face of two huge boulders at Mahabalipuram (Mamallapuram). But for us two twentieth-century trekkers this was only the first of many tales forced on us by our companion, who became increasingly dogmatic with each story told. The breaking point arrived on the third day after our companion had waxed at length about Lord Vishnu and the weaponry he had invented for the Hindu nation: jet aircraft, flying saucers, lasers and the atomic bomb – all Indian inventions. We had had enough, and while our unwanted companion dozed after tiffin we quietly packed and double-marched away from him – to no purpose, since he had us arrested on our return to Uttarkashi. He was, I should explain, a Brahmin deeply committed to his